AUSTRALIAN ACCESS FEDERATION

GUARDIANS Minimum Viable Policy Requirements

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Revision History

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Introduction

Led by Australian BioCommons and supported by the Australian Access Federation (AAF), the GUARDIANS project is building a unified, ethical digital infrastructure for human omics data. By standardising interfaces, governance, and identity management, the programme eliminates research fragmentation and access barriers. This streamlined environment accelerates genomics research through secure, world-class collaboration both in Australia and internationally.

Why policy matters for the GUARDIANS collaboration

GUARDIANS brings together universities, health services, research institutes, and technical providers, each with different systems, processes, and maturity levels. To function as a unified national collaboration, partners need a shared understanding of what "good practice" looks like. Policy provides that common foundation.

A strong policy baseline sets out the expectations, minimum standards, and responsibilities every partner agrees to follow. It ensures consistent identity, access, and data-handling decisions; protects sensitive genomic data; reduces confusion or duplicated effort; and creates a trusted environment where people, systems, and data can interact safely. Clear policies also guide partners on what to do when incidents occur, enabling swift and coordinated responses rather than improvisation.

Most importantly, shared policy signals collective responsibility. Partners operate with the same safeguards, governance principles, and assurance levels, strengthening trust across the ecosystem. This clarity and consistency allow GUARDIANS to scale effectively, support diverse organisational contexts, and maintain the integrity of the national collaboration as new partners join.

A simple analogy: GUARDIANS as a shared office building

Think of GUARDIANS as an office building shared by multiple organisations. Each organisation occupies its own offices but also share common spaces like meeting rooms and the main lobby. To keep everyone safe and ensure the building runs smoothly, the building manager sets rules about who can enter, how movement is controlled, and what spaces people can access.

- *Trusted employees* have access to shared meeting rooms, but not every private office.
- *Delivery personnel* can enter the lobby to drop off packages but are not allowed to roam freely.
- *Visitors sign in*, wear a badge, and are escorted.
- *Strangers* cannot move beyond the reception desk.

These rules ensure that people can work together efficiently while still protecting private spaces and preventing accidental or unauthorised access. Policies in GUARDIANS work the same way. They define clear permissions and boundaries so trusted collaborators can interact safely without exposing sensitive areas of the ecosystem. They make sure that access decisions are consistent, transparent, and appropriate,

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regardless of which organisation is making them. Just as an office buildings rely on access cards, sign-in processes, and security protocols, GUARDIANS relies on a shared policy framework to determine who can access which parts of its infrastructure, services, and data, as well as under what conditions.

Purpose of the MVP requirements
The Minimum Viable Policy (MVP) requirements form a collaboration-level baseline that all partners must adopt before connecting services to the GUARDIANS network or accessing services from other partners. The policy baseline establishes a trusted, consistent foundation of policies and controls creating a secure, interoperable environment across Australia and saving partners the complex task of determining their own interoperability standards.

Scope
These collaboration level requirements apply to all organisations participating in GUARDIANS, including all systems, services, data flows, and users interacting with GUARDIANS platforms or data. The scope defines the minimum expectations required for safe, secure, and interoperable participation in the collaboration.

In scope
This policy covers the shared requirements for:

- Identity and Access Management (IAM)
- Authentication and Authorisation (AuthN & AuthZ)
- Trust and assurance obligations across the collaboration
- Minimum operational responsibilities for partners
- Collaboration wide security and behavioural controls

The policy set also incorporates key areas defined in the Policy Development Kit, including:

- Operational security and incident response
- Fit-for-purpose membership management and identity assurance
- Data protection and privacy safeguards

Out of scope
This policy does not cover:

- Partner-internal policies and controls (e.g. all policies, frameworks, procedures outside of the GUARDIANS collaboration)
- Partner-only systems (e.g. HR, finance, any systems that partners own outside of GUARDIANS)
- Internal operational processes (e.g. local configuration or maintenance)

Policy Framework Context
The Policy Development Kit
The GUARDIANS MVP requirements are derived from the Policy Development Kit (PDK). PDK is a set of guiding documents designed to help research collaborations work together securely and effectively. It provides a modular, adaptable framework designed to support secure, scalable collaboration across diverse partners.

The PDK makes research collaborations easier by offering common principles and modular policies that can be tailored to the collaboration's context, legislative obligations, data sensitivity and existing agreements. These modular components are designed to be flexible, allowing organisations to adopt only the elements they need or integrate them gradually without disrupting existing frameworks. This modularity reduces implementation costs, simplifies updates, and supports scalability as your organisation grows or regulations change. For example, an organisation might start with a core identity management policy and later add data-sharing modules as new partnerships emerge. This approach sets clear expectations for partners and users, creating a foundation for secure, interoperable access. Furthermore, tailored for Australia, the PDK's alignment with international standards enables trusted international research collaboration.

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The PDK provides policies that:

- Define roles and responsibilities for all participants
- Set out expected behaviours within the collaboration
- Manage risks around personal data collection, storage and use

The MVP suite identifies the minimum subset needed to establish a functioning, trustworthy collaboration baseline.

Guiding Principles

All policies within this MVP suite must reflect the following pinciples:

- **Interoperability** – ensure policy and technical consistency across organisations.
- **Trust and Identity First** – establish and maintain strong, verifiable identity assurance processes.
- **Federated Access** – enable decentralised, secure access between partners without centralising identity stores.
- **Secure by Design** – embed security controls into all GUARDIANS services and workflows.
- **Minimum Viable Assurance** – set the lowest acceptable assurance threshold required for safe collaboration.
- **Shared Responsibility Model (Accountability)** – clear allocation of responsibilities for all partners and users.
- **Scalability and adaptability** – policies must support the initiative's national mission and evolve with new partners and technologies.
- **Privacy by Design** – minimise and safeguard sensitive or personal data.

Critical risks in GUARDIANS collaboration

The diversity in GUARDIANS strengthens the collaboration but introduces systemic risks that arise in any large, multi-partner ecosystem. The following list highlights the most critical collaboration risks that GUARDIANS must manage to maintain trust, consistency, and secure access to sensitive genomic data.

1. **Loss of National Interoperability (foundational risk)**
   This is the primary risk to the success of GUARDIANS. When partners implement GUARDIANS connections using their own local interpretations of identity, access, and assurance rather than a shared collaboration-level policy baseline, services can no longer reliably interoperate across organisations. The result is a federation in name only: technical connections exist, but the trust required for true interoperability does not. Cross-institution access becomes fragile, bespoke, and increasingly difficult to scale or support. Interoperability is the core principle of GUARDIANS. Without consistent policy adoption, GUARDIANS risks degrading into a set of fragmented, inconsistent services rather than a cohesive national platform.

2. **Policy and governance misalignment (including lack of central governance/leadership)**
   GUARDIANS partners operate under different internal policies, governance models, and risk appetites, leading to inconsistent interpretations of requirements around identity, privacy, data handling, and security. This variability is amplified by the absence of a central governance body or leadership structure with clear authority to make collaboration-wide decisions. Consequently there is no single point of direction, escalation, or arbitration. This absence of overarching governance creates uncertainty, encourages inconsistency, and makes it difficult to enforce minimum requirements or resolve disagreements. As a result, the project faces a structural challenge: without an empowered governance and leadership framework, GUARDIANS cannot maintain consistent standards across

3. **Inconsistent identity and access management practices**
   Each organisation manages identity proofing, role assignment, and deprovisioning differently. This variability can lead to mismatched assurance levels, stale or over-privileged accounts, and inconsistent role definitions. Because identity is the foundation of trust in GUARDIANS, differing identity access management practices introduce avoidable risks and increase the effort required to maintain consistent access controls. Each partner applies different assumptions about:
   - Identity assurance
   - MFA enforcement
   - Attribute quality

- Role definitions

Since same user may be trusted by one service but rejected by another, the access outcomes are unpredictable and hard to explain. Increased friction for reseachers and service users. Trust decisions move from policy-driven to implicit and undocumented.

4. **Divergent legal, ethical, and data stewardship interpretations**
   Partners interpret privacy legislation, ethics obligations, and data stewardship responsibilities differently depending on institutional context. This creates uncertainty about what data can be shared, under what conditions, and what constitutes compliant use. Such inconsistencies can stall data access workflows, cause friction between partners, and elevate organisational or project-level risk.

5. **Fragmented incident response and communication expectations**
   Security incident response is challenging enough inside an organisation but become significantly more complex in a federated environment. Incident response processes, severity classifications, reporting timelines, and communication protocols differ widely across organisations. During a multi-partner incident, differences in response procedures and communication protocols can delay detection, complicate escalation, or result in inconsistent messaging to users and stakeholders. Inconsistency poses substantive risks given the sensitivity of genomic data and the high expectations for coordinated breach response.

6. **Role ambiguity and responsibility confusion**
   Key roles such as Data Steward, Service Owner, Identity Provider Operator, and Security Lead are not defined consistently across partners. Variability in role assignment or responsibility boundaries leads to confusion, duplicated effort, or gaps in accountability. This can slow decisions, delay access workflows, and complicate incident handling.

7. **Collaboration fatigue and engagement drift**
   Because GUARDIANS requires ongoing active participation and accountability against shared requirements across many organisations, partners may experience fatigue over time, especially when balancing internal priorities.

8. **Scalability**
   Scalability will be much harder, slower and more labour intensive unless there is a solid policy framework. Any policy change must be renegotiated individually with each partner, creating delays and resistance because there is no clear or agreed starting point. As a result, policy evolution stalls and GUARDIANS risks remaining stuck at pilot maturity rather than maturing into a national-scale interoperable platform.

9. **Reputational risk to the GUARDIANS brand**
   Inconsistent access outcomes or avoidable incidents undermine confidence in the collaboration. If partners experience unreliable or unpredictable behaviour, GUARDIANS may be perceived as unreliable or poorly governed. This erodes trust, weakens the value proposition, and may discourage early adopters and future partners alike.

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MVP suite for GUARDIANS

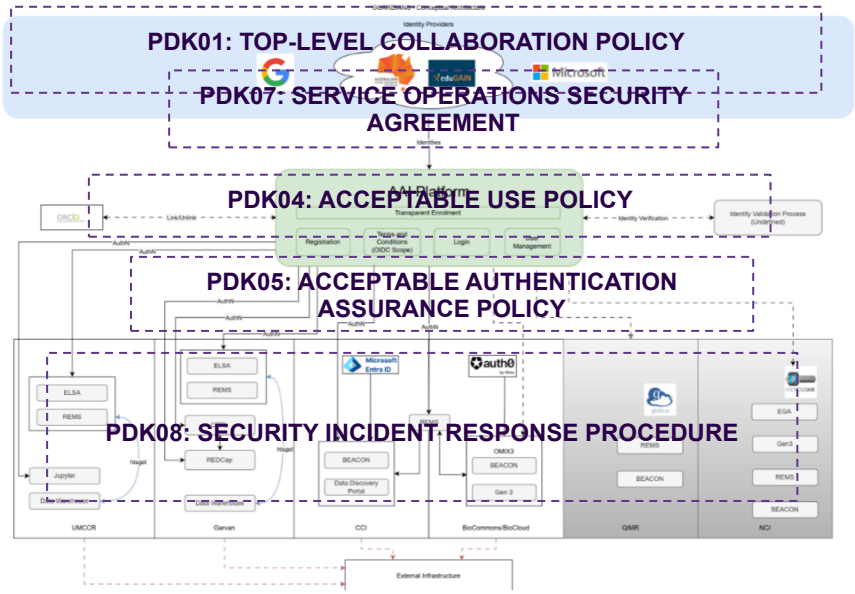

Figure 1: GUARDIANS Trust Framework

Figure 1 illustrates the modular suite of GUARDIANS framework that provides the common principles for collaboration-level policies required to govern the AAI Platform and partner services as a unified, secure ecosystem. By establishing clear expectations for identity assurance and data-sharing at the collaboration level, that all the services operate within a framework that is interoperable, governance-aligned, and scalable across all partners.

PDK01 and supporting policies (PDK04, 05, 07, 08) for GUARDIANS represents the essential set of policies needed to establish a secure, trusted, and interoperable collaboration environment. These policies provide a baseline framework that partners can adapt to their own context while ensuring consistent expectations for identity, security, and responsible use of shared infrastructure.

1. **PDK01: Top-Level Collaboration Policy**
   This is the foundation policy that sets the overall principles for trust, identity, and security within the collaboration. For GUARDIANS, it ensures all partners agree on shared expectations and responsibilities before engaging in technical or operational work.

2. **PDK04: Acceptable Use Policy**
   Defines what end users can and cannot do when using GUARDIANS infrastructure and services. It protects against misuse and clarifies acceptable behaviour, helping maintain trust and security across the collaboration.

3. **PDK05: Acceptable Authentication Assurance Policy**
   Specifies the minimum standards for identity verification and authentication. For GUARDIANS, this ensures that only properly authenticated users gain access to sensitive data and compute resources, reducing risks of impersonation or unauthorised access.

4. **PDK07: Service Operations Security Agreement**
   Outlines security requirements for any service joining the GUARDIANS collaboration. This policy ensures that all connected services meet baseline security standards, reducing vulnerabilities and maintaining interoperability.

5. **PDK08: Security Incident Response Procedure**
   Provides a clear process for detecting, reporting, and responding to security incidents. For GUARDIANS, this policy ensures quick, coordinated action during breaches or misuse, minimising impact and maintaining trust.

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While AAF considers this list to be essentials, GUARDIANS may want to consider the following policies:

- Privacy Policy (PDK02) – Ensures responsible handling of personal or sensitive data, which is critical if GUARDIANS processes identifiable information.
- Community Membership Management Policy (PDK06) – Defines how participants are added, removed, and managed within the collaboration, supporting accountability and governance.

The importance and value of a strong policy foundation
A strong policy foundation allows GUARDIANS to function as a coherent, secure, and trusted national collaboration. Policies define shared boundaries, expectations, and safeguards covering identity proofing, identity lifecycle management, and baseline authentication and authorisation controls. This makes cross-organisational data sharing and access decisions predictable and safe. With these shared commitments in place, partners can trust that consistent protections are being applied, enabling reliable interoperability across the collaboration.

Key roles and responsibilities
The GUARDIANS collaboration brings together many organisations with different internal structures, capabilities, and ways of working. To operate effectively as a shared national ecosystem, it is critical that all partners understand who is responsible for what, and how decisions are made across the collaboration.

At present, GUARDIANS does not have a formal governance lead or a permanent, empowered governance body in place. This creates uncertainty around decision-making, escalation pathways, and overall accountability.

The roles outlined in the following section provide a clear baseline of responsibilities needed to support consistent participation across partners, while also highlighting the importance of establishing a dedicated governance function as the collaboration matures.

Role	Primary responsibilities
Governance Lead / Programme Board	• Provides collaboration-wide leadership and decision-making • Approves policy updates, exceptions, and major escalations • Ensures consistency across partners • Oversees governance structure until a permanent body exists • Conventionally, the organisation responsible for distributing funding acts as the interim leadership authority, providing strategic direction and making key decisions on behalf of the collaboration until permanent governance arrangements are established • Alternatively, a governance board can be formed by appointing key representatives from participating partners, ensuring shared oversight, diverse expertise, and balanced decision-making across the collaboration
Policy & Compliance Lead (Programme-level)	• Maintains the MVP suite and supporting documents • Manages partner policy mapping and equivalency assessments • Tracks compliance evidence, exceptions, and gaps

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	• Reports collaboration-wide policy posture and status
Identity Governance Lead (Programme-level)	• Oversees identity assurance requirmements and attribute standards • Ensures consistency in join/change/leave processes across partners • Monitors identity freshness, role quality, and lifecycle adherence and declare any deviations
Identity Provider (IdP) Operator (Partner-level)	• Implements identity proofing, MFA, and assurance levels • Maintains accurate identity attributes and timely de-provisioning and notify changes where required • Supports federation hygiene (metadata, key rotation) • Acts as liaison for identity-related incidents
Security / Incident Response Lead (Programme-level or Partner-level)	• Coordinates multi-partner incident response under PDK08 • Maintains incident response plans, contacts, severity model, and communication pathways • Leads post-incident reviews and corrective action tracking
Data Steward / Data Custodian (Partner-level)	• Applies data classification and purpose-limitation rules • Confirms compliance with ethics, custodial agreements, and approvals • Ensures access to sensitive data is strictly authorised and monitored
Partner Executive Sponsor	• Confirms organisational commitment to GUARDIANS • Approves resourcing and internal uplift activities • Ensures alignment with strategic priorities within their organisation
End Users (Researchers, Operators, Analysts)	• Follow Acceptable Use Policy • Protect credentials and MFA devices • Use approved tools and environments • Report issues or suspected incidents promptly

RACI Matrix

The following RACI matrix outlines how key responsibilities are shared across the GUARDIANS collaboration. Because GUARDIANS involves many partners with different internal structures and maturity levels, the matrix provides a simple way to clarify who is **R**esponsible, **A**ccountable, **C**onsulted, and **I**nformed for each core activity. This ensures that all partners understand their role in delivering the MVP suite.

Activity	Governance Lead/Programme Board	Policy & Compliance Lead	Identity Governance Lead	IdP Operator	Security SP Owner/Operator	Security /IR Lead	Data Steward/Custodian	Partner Executive Sponsor
Approve MVP suite & Updates	A	R	C	I	I	C	C	C
Define/establish governance model	A	C	C	I	I	C	I	R
Partner policy mapping & attestation (PDK01)	C	A/R	C	I	I	I	I	R
Identity assurance onboarding (PDK05)	I	C	A/R	R	I	C	I	I
Service security onboarding (PDK07)	I	C	I	I	A/R	C	C	I
AUP communication & user acknowledgement (PDK04)	I	A/R	C	C	C	I	C	I
Incident response readiness & annual exercises (PDK08)	C	C	I	C	C	A/R	C	I
Exception review & approval	A	R	C	C	C	C	C	I
Metrics reporting (MFA, patching, logs, IR)	C	A/R	C	R	R	R	R	I
Annual review & partner feedback loop	A	R	C	C	C	C	C	I

Approach to building a trusted MVP suite

Our approach to developing the GUARDIANS MVP suite is centred on creating a policy foundation that is practical, consistent, and grounded in the day-to-day realities of how partners operate. Rather than seeking to impose a one-size-fits-all model, we are designing a suite of minimum requirements that can be meaningfully applied across universities, health services, research institutes, and technical service providers, regardless of their internal structures or maturity levels.

A key part of this work is the ongoing gap analysis, which helps us understand the current landscape across partner organisations. By reviewing existing policies, procedures, and governance practices, we can identify not only where strong alignment already exists, but also where gaps or inconsistencies may undermine interoperability or introduce risk. This process is deliberately iterative: as partners continue to share their materials and experiences, our understanding evolves, giving us a clearer view of the sector's readiness and the areas where additional guidance may be needed.

Engagement is central to this approach. Through workshops, conversations, and targeted policy reviews, we are building a shared view of what is achievable, what is necessary, and where organisations may need support in uplifting their internal frameworks. These engagements ensure that the policy suite reflects real operational challenges and does not place unreasonable burdens on partners. Instead, it provides a baseline that is both credible and implementable.

The insights gathered through this collaborative process directly inform the development of supporting tools and guidance, which will help partners apply the MVP suite within their own contexts. While implementation remains the responsibility of each organisation, our role is to make the pathway to adoption clearer by offering structure, examples, and practical starting points.

By combining structured analysis with genuine co-design, we are shaping a policy foundation that partners can adopt with confidence. An MVP suite that strengthens governance, reduces ambiguity, and supports a secure and trusted national ecosystem for GUARDIANS.

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Conclusion
A coherent MVP suite is essential for enabling GUARDIANS to function as a secure, trusted, interoperable, and nationally consistent ecosystem.

The MVP requirements outlined in this document provide the shared baseline that partners need to uphold effective governance, maintain consistent decision-making, and protect sensitive genomic data across organisational boundaries. While implementation rests with each organisation, the accompanying PDK will support partners in interpreting and applying these requirements in their own contexts, ensuring the policy suite can be taken forward in a practical and sustainable way.

Together, the MVP and the PDK establish the foundation for a strong, future-ready collaboration, one built on clarity, accountability, and the shared policy structures necessary for GUARDIANS to operate with confidence and integrity.

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